CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Reading Guide

Last updated: 2026-10-25

About This Report

This is an experimental, AI-driven research project from SRL. SRL is independent, with no outside funding and no sponsors. This tracker is a summarized pull of the public record, kept as a coherent, concise news update. It draws on the CA/Browser Forum's own ballots, mailing lists and published documents, and on the public sources of the browser root programs. An AI model reads those sources and writes the summary, and every statement links to the source it came from. Where two sources disagree, both are reported. AI makes mistakes, so check the linked source before relying on any statement. The tracker is updated each week that the public record shows a change.

The CA/Browser Forum decides what a publicly trusted certificate may contain, how its holder must be checked, and how long it may live. Its decisions reach almost every encrypted connection on the internet, and they are made in public by a body most people have never heard of. This collection follows that body and the browser root programs that enforce its rules [1].

The collection has six parts. Every part stands on its own, and every statement carries a numbered citation to a public source. Where two sources disagree, the disagreement is reported rather than resolved. This edition replaces the one of 19 October, and it is refreshed each week that the Forum's public record shows a change.

The week to 25 October was the most eventful since this collection began. A certificate authority's intermediate keys turned out to be recoverable, two browsers removed one of its roots within three days, and the authority announced its exit from public website certificates. Parts 4 and 5 carry that story, and Part 1 carries the first draft rule written in response to it.

1. How To Read a Forum Decision

One distinction governs this whole subject, and getting it wrong is the most common error in reporting on the Forum.

A ballot that passes its vote is not yet a rule. The Forum's decisions move through five states, and only the last two bind anyone.

A ballot is first **proposed**, drafted and argued in a discussion period of at least seven days. It then enters a **voting** period of seven days. If it passes it is **adopted**, which starts a 30-day intellectual property review. Only after that review does the text **publish** into a numbered version of a guideline. A separate effective date decides when it is **in force**, and that date is often a year or more after publication.

The practical consequence is that three different true statements can be made about the same ballot, and only one of them means certificate authorities must do anything. This collection states the stage every time. Where a requirement has a future effective date, that date is given.

The unit that carries through all of it is the ballot identifier. Those identifiers are stable and prefixed by working group, so SC is the Server Certificate group, CSC is Code Signing, SMC is S/MIME, NS is Network Security, and FORUM is Forum-level governance [2].

2. The Parts

Each part covers one working group or one enforcement layer.

Part 1, Server Certificate Working Group. The busiest group, governing the certificates that secure websites. It covers the ballots and document versions, domain control validation, and certificate profiles, including the schedule that is cutting certificate lifetimes toward 47 days by 2029. One ballot is in its vote, the post-quantum draft has been closed and handed over, and a new draft on key quality answers the week's compromise. This is the part to read first if you only read one.

Part 2, Code Signing Working Group. The rules for certificates that sign software. A smaller group, with one ballot that has closed its vote and awaits its result, and one that has not moved since spring.

Part 3, S/MIME Working Group. The rules for certificates that sign and encrypt email. It is the one place in the Forum where post-quantum algorithms are already permitted in published requirements. Its newest ballot passed unanimously this week and is in review, and it is working on composite signatures.

Part 4, Public Trust Programs. The enforcement layer. Mozilla, Google, Microsoft and Apple each decide who is actually trusted, and their policies routinely demand more than the Forum does, earlier. This part covers their post-quantum plans, the incident record, the first emergency root removal of the autumn, and the completion of the largest revocation.

Part 5, Revocation and Transparency. The two mechanisms for recovering from a certificate that should not exist. Both were exercised this week, revocation by a key compromise and a 400,000-certificate clean-up, and transparency by a flood of proof-of-concept certificates that forced one operator to close its logs.

Part 6, Governance, Network Security and Standards. It covers the Forum's officers and new members, the network security requirements, and the IETF standards and audit regimes the guidelines depend on.

3. What This Collection Does Not Cover

Scope boundaries, stated so that an absence is not read as a finding.

Post-quantum algorithm standardization belongs to a separate collection. This collection records what the Forum permits in a certificate, not how the underlying algorithms are chosen or specified. Part 6 follows the IETF only where a draft becoming a standard changes what the Forum's documents may cite.

Each part records its own gaps in the relevant section, rather than leaving them silent. Where a Forum web page lags its own mailing list, the list is treated as the record and the lag is reported.

Sources

1. CA/Browser Forum - CA/Browser Forum - https://cabforum.org/ - as of 2026-10-25
2. All CA/Browser Forum Ballots - CA/Browser Forum - https://cabforum.org/ballots/ - as of 2026-10-25